

Chapter 1 Accounting Succinctly

Computer developers are frequently asked to create systems to assist a client in running his or her business. While the developer has the tools (e.g., SQL Server, C#, Visual Studio, etc.) to produce solid applications, the client has the knowledge of the business that needs to be computerized.

Unfortunately, most of the clients are not developers. (If they were, why would they hire programmers in the first place?)

The meeting of these two kinds of expertise is often fraught with miscommunication. The client explains his or her needs to the developer who, in turn, tries to convert those needs into a design and, eventually, into a running application. Often, after the client sees the finished program, he or she then has a clearer picture of what he or she wants the computer to do and, unfortunately, that picture frequently looks nothing like the program the developer wrote.

This disconnect (between the customer's explanations of his or her needs and how they are seen by all of the other roles in development) has been known for a long time, as shown in Figure 1. The tree swing diagram has been used for years and, although the artwork has improved, the concept remains true to this day:

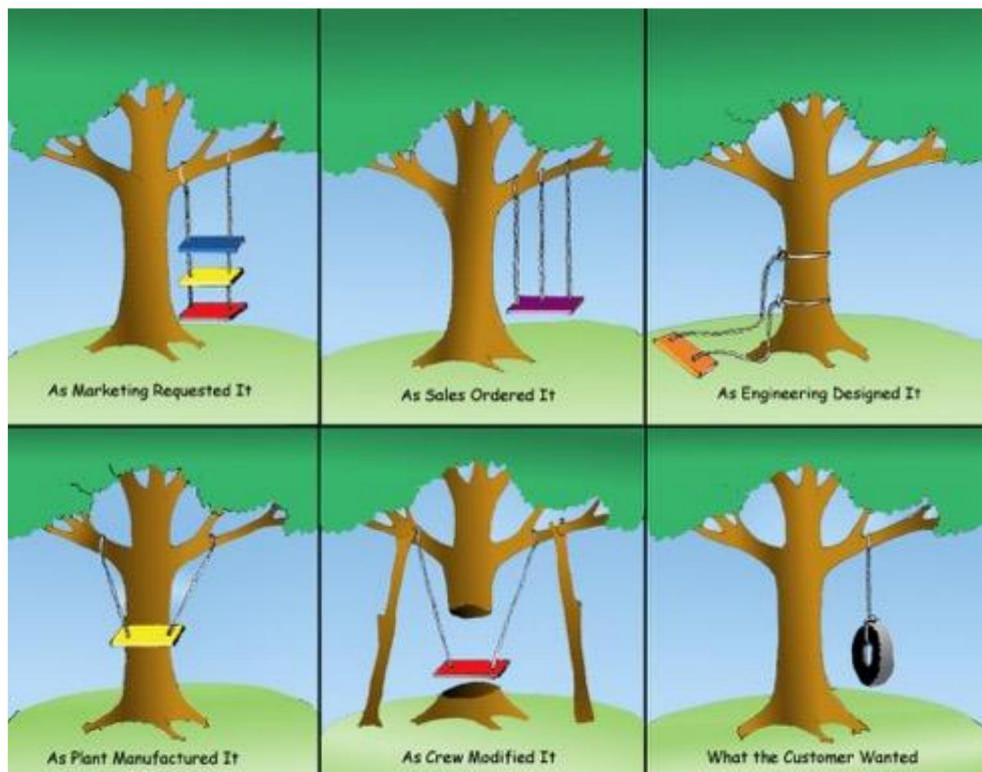


Figure 1: Tree swing diagram, courtesy of the [Monolithic Dome Institute](#)